



Man of the moment: Jugraj Singh was the game-changer for the Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers in the HIL Final.

HOCKEYINDIA

arguably the strongest team — in the final. “Our players were quite old, so most teams underrated us as the lowest-ranked side. It was all about working on the mental side of the game and behaving like Tigers. I told the players a lion has only one mentality: to go for the kill,” said a proud Deepak Thakur, the Tigers’ assistant coach.

The Toofans had remained unbeaten in regulation time across eight matches before the final but were undone by a hat-trick from Jugraj, who finished as the tournament’s top scorer with 12 goals.

Rise of young stars

One of the biggest takeaways from HIL was the emergence of young talent. The Toofans’ reliance on their youthful core paid dividends. Twenty-two-year-old defender Amandeep Lakra (**right**) flourished under the mentorship of Gonzalo Peillat, scoring in both the semifinal and final to finish the campaign with

five goals. Lakra, who grew up near the Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium in Rourkela, thrilled the local crowd with his family in attendance. Meanwhile, the standout find of the tournament was Toofans’ dynamic forward, Arshdeep Singh. His dazzling skills, direct play, and three-goal tally earned him a maiden call-up to the senior national team for the upcoming FIH Pro League.

The HIL also shone a spotlight on several domestic players who have long been toiling away, such as

Mohammed Raheel and Affan Yousuf. Fulton, watching from the ‘Tower’ behind the goal, would have undoubtedly taken note of more names for his watchlist.

Tactical growth

All eight teams were led by overseas head coaches, bringing coaching expertise from Europe and Australia. This exposure provided domestic players — many without international experience — the opportunity to understand different tactical systems and styles of play, a crucial learning curve before making the next step in their careers.

“I think they gain plenty of experience from this. Then, when they go away, they need to reflect on what they’ve learned, talk to senior players and coaches, and absorb the lessons that way. They’re exposed to incredible players — what an environment for them to grow in,” said Tigers’ Australian head coach Colin Batch after the final.

Toofans’ head coach, Dutchman Pasha Gademan, highlighted how the HIL helped Indian players develop their tactical awareness. “If I were to go to Europe and build a new team,

